

CHRISTIAN PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT — REFORMATION RESTRAINT

A CAUTIOUS APPROACH TO DEMANDING SOCIETAL OUTCOMES

God is at work in the world — even through people who don't believe in Him.

It seems there is so much to be angry about these days, and everyone thinks that they have the answers that will make it all better. We've all witnessed and can understand that widespread sentiment that we are just one more resolution, one more bill, or one more election away from getting everything right. Then we'll be at peace. Then our problems will be solved. What does the two-kingdom, Christian citizen do?

When it comes to ideas for radically changing things "to get it right," a Two-Kingdom citizen ought to be hesitant at first. Why? He or she knows that God is at work in the world through the left-hand Kingdom, even through people who aren't believers in Him. Likewise, the outcomes God brings about are often very different from what we believe is the perfect future, and as Christians we ought to accept that fact with humility, recognizing that God's ways are higher than ours. This is what we call Reformation Restraint – restraining ourselves from prematurely seeking zealous reforms before we stop to see what God may be doing with institutions and authorities that appear unworthy to us.

When you understand what God is doing through His left hand Kingdom (preserving a society that furthers the spread of the gospel), you can understand how He can even use sinful, unbelieving people to promote peace and temporal justice. Think of all the people right now who are doing a "good" job in their vocations as politicians, police, entrepreneurs, business people, and even fathers and mothers, even though they aren't Christian. They know, however, that they need to do the right thing for others in their work. Is that optimal? No. But God works through that to keep a neighborhood, a community, and even a nation from imploding.

My Kingdom is not of this world.

JOHN 18:36

Martin Luther captured the essence of this Two-kingdom teaching in his writings. Christians need to remember Christ's words to Pilate in John 18:36 and restrain themselves from trying to legislate God's Kingdom into existence here on earth. So, most of the time, we Christians let the rulers rule, enjoying the temporal peace and security God brings us through them, and not demanding a theocracy built around our own utopian vision.

Nevertheless, our Christian respect for those in authority is not absolute. As Acts 5:29 teaches, “we must obey God rather than men.” Romans 13 teaches that the government is to be a terror to evil doers and an encouragement to those who do good, and when the government oversteps its God-given left-hand kingdom role and begins to persecute the church for speaking the truth about good and evil (like it is even here in America with those who speak out against abortion and gay marriage) we can and must speak out all the more. Even so, it is not with a rebellious heart that we resist evil government, but a loving heart that earnestly “desires all to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.” (1 Timothy 2:4)

Reformation Restraint is the belief that God is at work in the world, even through unbelievers, and that he has a plan to achieve the best for every person. Jesus himself tells us that “all authority in heaven and on earth” has been given to Him. Restraint, therefore, is recognition that God has instituted government, and even if living Christian life demands resistance to that government, God’s people still eagerly wait to see his plan. Reformation restraint means counting on him, even when we’re tempted to take matters into our own hands.

TALK IT THROUGH

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Work through these with your group, then with a friend or your spouse — without the sheet.

1

What does it mean to you to practice restraint when it comes to left-hand kingdom involvement?

2

What is the advantage of practicing restraint when it comes to responding to political, cultural, and social issues?

3

Why does the Christian practice restraint when it comes to open rebellion against a law?
